

Andrew W. Shenstone

Shenstone, Andrew - Application for Senior Software Engineer, Web API Platform @ Scribd

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SUMMARY

I am applying for Senior Software Engineer, Web API Platform because the role is greenfield API platform work on top of existing systems—exactly the shape of problems I have shipped: **Ruby on Rails GraphQL** at Bloom, platform **GraphQL** evolution at Tilia, and intentional data boundaries on Plantfolio (**Next.js**, **PostgreSQL**, async workers).

I have 12+ years in software engineering with a platform-leaning full-stack path. I design APIs with clear contracts, pagination and caching in mind, and production health (tests, observability, failure modes) as part of the design—not afterthoughts. I partner with frontend and backend teams, document integration patterns, and work AI-natively (Cursor top 1%) for speed with human ownership of schema and risk.

I have not owned a company-wide REST gateway at Scribd scale by title; I have built and maintained shared GraphQL and typed server layers that multiple clients depended on, and I am motivated by Web Modernization as a long-term mandate. gRPC in production would be a ramp; REST and GraphQL tradeoffs are daily vocabulary for me.

SKILLS

Web API platform: Product-facing API design: GraphQL in production (Bloom Rails API, Tilia platform); REST and typed server-action boundaries on Plantfolio, Ruby on Rails (~6 years through Rails 6): integrated and extended GraphQL APIs shared across web and mobile clients, Contracts, versioning mindset, and testing: high coverage at Tilia; Vitest/Cypress and CI on Plantfolio, Performance-aware APIs: pagination, filtering, caching, and search (Algolia); dual-database and event-driven indexing patterns, gRPC: familiar with tradeoffs from platform reading; not my primary production integration style today

Modern web & developer experience: React and Next.js (App Router, Server Components) in production—partner with frontend teams on integration patterns, TypeScript monorepos (Turborepo, pnpm); clear package boundaries for safer cross-team consumption, Observability and failure modes as part of design: Sentry, structured errors, async retries via Inngest, Champion API usage through docs, review, and pairing—not only implementation

Data, async & cloud: PostgreSQL and Prisma; MongoDB in production before migration—relational and document modeling tradeoffs, Inngest, webhooks, background workers; ETL-style pipelines (Tune), AWS (S3, EC2); Vercel for Next.js deployments

AI-native product & workflow: AI-native product delivery: vision, conversational UX, RAG/embeddings in production (Plantfolio), OpenAI API, AI SDK, vector embeddings, AI-assisted engineering: Cursor (top 1% user), Claude Code—class workflows—daily practice since the current wave of coding agents, not a recent experiment, Codebases structured for agent-friendly work: typed TypeScript monorepos, tests, clear package boundaries

EDUCATION

B.S. Finance, Santa Clara University — 2010

EXPERIENCE

Founder & Lead Engineer

Plantfolio | November 2023 - Present

API & platform boundaries

- Owned product-facing data access through typed server actions and shared packages—not a public REST surface—so web clients get clear contracts, predictable query shapes, and centralized error handling
- Event-driven async (Inngest, webhooks, change-stream worker) for search indexing, rendering, and side effects; designed integration boundaries so

synchronous reads stay fast under real catalog volume (40,000+ species)

- Dual PostgreSQL databases with Prisma; pagination, filtering, and Algolia-backed search with performance and cache-friendly access patterns in mind
- Public architecture documentation for onboarding engineers and consistent integration patterns across apps

AI-native product & engineering

- Built Plantfolio as an AI-native application: plant ID from photos, contextual assistant (Sage), smart tag extraction, and semantic search over 40,000+ species—LLM features customers use in production, not demos
- AI-native way of building: Cursor (top 1% user) and Claude-class agents are my default workflow from early in the product; I own architecture and review while using AI for speed across the 12+ package monorepo
- Designed the monorepo for agent-friendly iteration—TypeScript, clear boundaries, Vitest/Cypress, and consistent patterns so AI-assisted shipping stays maintainable

Product Leadership & Architecture

- Architected and built a comprehensive plant management platform from the ground up, serving as both technical lead and product owner
- Owned the full feature cycle: joined customer calls to identify friction points, architected solutions, implemented, tested, and verified success in production
- Led product strategy and user experience decisions, making product micro-decisions and navigating ambiguity to deliver value iteratively

Senior Software Engineer

Tilia | January 2023 - August 2023

- Introduced and evolved a GraphQL API on the payments platform while building product on top of it—hands-on with schema design, resolvers, and typed client integration

- Partnered with cross-functional teams on KYC and risk-adjacent tooling where API contracts and test coverage had to hold under production scrutiny
 - Maintained 90%+ unit test coverage on the Tools application plus E2E tests; treated API regressions as product incidents
 - Mentored engineers through pairing and code review (no direct reports)
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Senior Software Engineer

Bloom.wine | September 2020 - October 2022

- Engineered Ruby on Rails GraphQL APIs consumed by Next.js admin, web, and mobile—primary integration layer between modern frontends and existing Rails systems
 - Architected greenfield Next.js admin; reduced coupling by standardizing how clients fetched and mutated domain data through the shared API
 - Integrated Shopify Plus, Stripe, and operator tooling where API design had to respect regulated retail constraints and real money flows
 - CI/CD with CircleCI; mentored via pairing and review (no direct reports)
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Software Engineer II

Tune Inc - Marketplace Automation | August 2019 - May 2020

- Built and operated ETL-style data pipelines and integrations supporting marketplace automation workflows
- Automated a client workflow using a Node.js/Express API and React.js, reducing the time to complete the task from 10-15 minutes to 10-30 seconds
- Modernized the primary legacy React.js application by moving from a custom Webpack process to react-scripts, resulting in a 50% reduction in production build size and a 60% reduction in NPM dependencies
- Reduced development machine CPU usage from 75% to <5% by simplifying the build pipeline and dependency graph

- Role ended in a company-wide layoff
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Software Developer

Ply Interactive Inc | June 2014 - July 2019

React Native

- Shipped multiple production React Native applications for agency clients—cross-platform mobile apps delivered end to end
- Washington State Fair: React Native app in sustained multi-year production; very high traffic during fair season, from tens of thousands of users into the hundreds of thousands cumulatively over seasons

Web & platforms

- Developed numerous web applications including Georgetownbeer.com, WashingtonWine.org, TwoWolvesWine.com, Novaerus.com, WellAir, and Plasma-air.com
- Built a standalone Ruby gem Content Management System, enabling simplified content management within Ruby on Rails projects
- Transitioned the agency to modern technologies like GraphQL, Gatsby.js, and React.js, improving delivery times for new projects
- Bloom.wine Product Development: Built extensive reporting features using complex PostgreSQL queries and interactive filtering, saving clients thousands of hours on previously manual tasks
- Engineered a flexible Wine Club membership structure for wineries, allowing for diverse client configuration and broadening the range of potential sales targets
- Communicated and enforced the standards of Shopify's Polaris React.js component library with designers, resulting in efficiencies gained from leveraging pre-built components

COMPANY REFERENCE

Plantfolio (2023-Present) - AI-native plant management platform (vision, chat, RAG search); built with AI-assisted engineering (Cursor-first) and 40,000+ species catalog - plantfolio.garden/

Tilia (2023) - All-in-one payment platform for digital economies - tilia.io/

Bloom.wine (2020-2022) - Commerce services for the alcohol industry; all clients on Shopify Plus - bloom.wine/

Tune Inc - Marketplace Automation (2019-2020) - SaaS platform for managing marketing partnerships across mobile and web - tune.com/

Ply Interactive Inc (2014-2019) - Boutique agency: web and production React Native apps (e.g. Washington State Fair at major scale); developed Bloom.wine product internally (2017-2019)